

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 112: DISCERNMENT OF SPIRITS (BIBLICAL AND DOCTRINAL FOUNDATIONS)

Introduction: Why Discernment Is Foundational

When we read the New Testament carefully, one thing becomes clear: not every spiritual experience comes from God. The Bible does not assume that anything supernatural is automatically true, good, or divine. From the very beginning of the Church, believers were warned that deception would be a real and present danger.

Jesus Himself made this a central concern. In Gospel of Matthew 24:4, He says, *“Take heed that no one deceives you.”* This warning shows that the greatest threat to believers is not only persecution or open rejection of God, but also falsehood that looks spiritual and convincing.

What Is “Discernment of Spirits”?

Discernment of spirits means the God-given ability to recognize the true source behind a spiritual activity, message, or influence. In simple terms, it answers the question: *“Is this from God, from human origin, or from an evil spirit?”*

Discernment: The ability to judge carefully, to distinguish between what is true and false, right and wrong. It involves both understanding and spiritual sensitivity.

Spirits: In this context, refers to unseen spiritual influences. The Bible teaches that there are different kinds:

The **Holy Spirit** (God’s Spirit)

Human spirit (conscience, fellowship and intuition)

Evil spirits (also called demons)

A key biblical instruction appears in First Epistle of John 4:1: *“Test the spirits, whether they are of God.”* This command makes it clear that believers are expected to examine spiritual matters, not accept them blindly.

A Biblical View of Spiritual Reality

The Bible presents a world where spiritual forces are active and involved in human life. This is part of what theologians call **spiritual warfare**: the ongoing conflict between God’s truth and forces that oppose it.

Because of this reality: Not every prophecy is from God; Not every miracle proves divine approval; Not every spiritual feeling is trustworthy.

This is why discernment is necessary. Without it, a person may confuse emotional intensity, charisma, or even supernatural signs with the presence of God.

Why Discernment Is Foundational, Not Optional

Discernment is not a special skill only for pastors, prophets, or “spiritual experts.” **It is essential for every believer.**

Why?

Protection from deception

False teachings and influences often appear convincing. Discernment helps believers recognize error before it takes root.

Spiritual stability

A believer who lacks discernment may be sincere but easily misled. Sincerity alone is not enough; truth must guide it.

Faithful relationship with God

Discernment helps believers respond rightly to God and avoid being drawn away by false voices.

In Epistle to the Hebrews 5:14, mature believers are described as those who “*have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil.*” This shows that discernment grows with training and practice.

As we study discernment, it is important to avoid two extremes:

Paranoia: Seeing demons or deception in everything

Naivety: Accepting everything as spiritual and from God

Biblical discernment is balanced. It is careful, but not fearful. It is thoughtful, but not suspicious of everything.

True discernment is grounded in two things:

Scripture (the Word of God): The Bible is the final authority. Every spiritual experience must be tested against its teaching.

The Holy Spirit: The Holy Spirit guides believers internally, helping them recognize truth and error. This is not based on feelings alone, but on alignment with God’s Word.

Purpose of This Course

This course is designed to train believers to: **See clearly in spiritual matters** without confusion or fear, **Judge rightly using Scripture** without arrogance or pride, **Test spiritual influences carefully** without rejecting genuine works of God.

The goal is not to produce suspicion, but maturity. Not fear, but clarity. Not pride, but faithfulness.

A believer who grows in discernment becomes steady, grounded, and able to walk wisely with God in a world where not everything spiritual is true.

The Biblical Reality of Multiple Spiritual Sources

When we read Scripture carefully, we see that reality is not only physical but also spiritual. The Bible presents life as taking place on more than one level. This means that not every thought, feeling, or experience comes from the same source. Some influences are from God, but others are not. Because of this, Christians are called to practice (live by) **discernment**: that is, the ability to recognize and distinguish between different spiritual influences.

The Bible points to at least four main sources of spiritual activity:

1. The Spirit of God

This refers to the Holy Spirit, the third Person of the Trinity. He is fully God and works in believers to guide, teach, convict of sin, and produce godly character. His influence always leads toward truth, holiness, and obedience to God.

2. The human spirit

This is the inner, non-physical part of a person—the seat of thoughts, desires, and intentions. Not everything we experience spiritually is divine; sometimes it is simply our own internal response, shaped by our personality, emotions, or understanding.

3. Demonic spirits

These are fallen angels who oppose God and seek to deceive, tempt, and disrupt human lives. Scripture treats them as real personal beings, not merely symbols of evil. Their activity is always contrary to God's truth and purposes.

4. The flesh (fallen human nature)

The term “flesh” in Scripture does not simply mean the physical body. It refers to the sinful nature within humanity that resists God. This inner tendency pulls a person toward self-centeredness, disobedience, and sin.

The apostle Paul highlights this complex reality. In Epistle to the Ephesians 6:12, he explains that believers are not ultimately struggling against other people (“*flesh and blood*”) but against spiritual forces. This reminds us that there is an unseen dimension to many of our struggles. At the same time, in Epistle to the Galatians 5:17, Paul teaches that the flesh is in conflict with the Spirit. This shows that even within a person, there can be opposing influences.

Taken together, these passages show why discernment is necessary. Spiritual influence is real, active, and often mixed. Not everything that feels spiritual is from God, and not everything that is internal is neutral.

If we ignore this complexity, we tend to fall into one of two errors. On one side is **naivety**, where a person assumes that every spiritual experience is from God. On the other side is **superstition**, where a person attributes too much to spiritual forces and sees them everywhere. A balanced biblical view avoids both extremes by taking the spiritual world seriously while remaining grounded in Scripture.

Discernment Defined Biblically

To understand discernment in a biblical way, we need to begin with the language of the New Testament itself. One key word used is the Greek term *diakrisis*. This word carries the idea of **distinguishing, separating, or making a careful judgment between things that may look alike on the surface**. In simple terms, discernment is the ability to tell the difference between what is true and false, right and wrong, or from God and not from God—even when the difference is not obvious.

It is important to say clearly what discernment is *not*. Discernment is not the same as suspicion or constant doubt. A suspicious person assumes something is wrong without good reason. Discernment, on the other hand, is a **trained and thoughtful response**. It involves paying attention, weighing things carefully, and making judgments based on truth.

A key passage that helps us understand this is Epistle to the Hebrews 5:14: “*But solid food is for the mature, who by constant use have trained themselves to distinguish good from evil.*”

Let’s walk through this verse slowly.

First, the writer speaks about “*the mature.*” This tells us that discernment is connected to **spiritual maturity**. A new believer may not yet have the ability to recognize subtle differences between truth and error. That ability grows over time. Maturity here does not simply mean age or how long someone has been in church; it refers to **spiritual development**—a life shaped by God’s truth.

Second, the phrase “*by constant use*” (or “practice”) shows that discernment is not automatic. It is something that must be **developed through repeated exercise**. Just like physical muscles grow stronger with use, spiritual perception becomes sharper through regular engagement with God’s Word and obedience to it.

Third, the writer says they have “*trained their senses.*” The word “*senses*” points to **perception**: the inner ability to recognize and evaluate what is happening. This suggests that discernment is not only intellectual (knowing facts), but also **perceptive**: learning to recognize patterns, motives, and spiritual realities.

Fourth, the goal of this training is “*to distinguish good from evil.*” This shows that discernment is both **ethical and spiritual**. It is about recognizing what aligns with God’s character and what opposes it. It is not just about making wise choices in general, but about identifying what is truly right before God.

When we put all this together, a clear picture emerges: discernment is a **developed ability**, not an instant gift that appears fully formed at conversion. When someone becomes a Christian, they receive new life, but they still need to grow in understanding.

Discernment develops through:

Obedience: putting God’s Word into practice

Exposure to truth: regularly engaging with Scripture

Spiritual formation: a gradual shaping of the heart and mind by the Holy Spirit

So, in biblical terms, discernment is the learned ability to recognize and judge rightly between competing influences, based on God's truth. It grows over time and becomes clearer as a believer matures.

God's Command to Test, Not Assume

A careful reading of the New Testament shows that discernment is not just a helpful skill: it is a **clear command**. One of the strongest statements of this comes from First Epistle of John 4:1: "*Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God...*"

If we slow down and follow John's wording, several important truths come into view.

First, the command "**do not believe every spirit**" assumes that multiple spiritual influences exist and that **not all of them are trustworthy**. John is writing to Christians, not outsiders, which means this warning applies *within* the believing community. Faith, in this sense, is not blind acceptance. It must be guided by truth.

Second, the phrase "**test the spirits**" is central. The word "test" (Greek: *dokimazō*) means to **examine, evaluate, or prove something carefully before accepting it**. It was used in the ancient world for testing metals to see if they were genuine. In the same way, believers are called to examine spiritual claims and experiences before receiving them as true.

This shows that discernment involves:

Criteria - there must be a standard by which something is judged

Patience - testing takes time; it is not rushed

Judgment - a conclusion must be reached, not avoided

John does not tell believers to reject everything, nor to accept everything. Instead, he calls for **careful evaluation**.

Third, John adds the reason: "...because many false prophets have gone out into the world."

This introduces another key term.

A **false prophet** is someone who claims to speak for God but does not truly represent Him. Their message may sound convincing or spiritual, but it is ultimately **misleading or false**. The presence of such people makes discernment necessary, not optional.

This same concern appears in other parts of the New Testament. In Acts of the Apostles 20:29–30, Paul warns the Ephesian elders: *“After my departure, fierce wolves will come in among you... and from among your own selves will arise men speaking twisted things...”*

Notice the emphasis: the danger comes **“among you”** and even **“from among your own selves.”** This means false teaching is not only an external threat; it can arise **within the church community itself.**

Similarly, in Second Epistle to the Corinthians 11:13–15, Paul writes: *“Such men are false apostles, deceitful workmen, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ... even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.”*

Here, the key idea is **deception through appearance.** False teachers do not usually look dangerous. They often appear sincere, persuasive, and even spiritually impressive. This is why **sincerity alone is not a reliable guide to truth.**

Taken together, these passages give us a strong theological foundation:

Spiritual claims must not be accepted automatically

Truth is not determined by how sincere or convincing something appears

False influences can exist inside the church, not just outside it

God expects believers to actively evaluate what they hear and experience

So, when we define discernment in this context, we can say:

Discernment is the **obedient practice of testing spiritual claims, teachings, and experiences against the truth of God’s Word in order to determine their true source.**

This command challenges two common mistakes. One is **blind acceptance**, where everything spiritual is assumed to be from God. The other is **fearful rejection**, where everything is treated with suspicion. Scripture calls for neither extreme. Instead, it calls for **careful, informed, and faithful testing.**

In simple terms, God does not ask His people to guess - He asks them to **test, examine, and judge rightly.**

Christological Discernment as the Central Test

When the New Testament teaches discernment, it does not leave us without a clear standard. At the center of all true discernment is **Christology**: that is, the truth about who Jesus Christ is and what He has done. In simple terms, Christology asks: *What is being said about Jesus, and is it faithful to what Scripture teaches?*

This idea comes directly from First Epistle of John 4:2–3: *“By this you know the Spirit of God: every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God...”*

If we read this carefully, John is giving a **test**. The word “confess” here does not simply mean saying the right words. It means **openly affirming and aligning with the truth about Jesus**. In John’s context, this included affirming that Jesus truly came “in the flesh”: that He is fully God and fully human, not a spiritual illusion or a lesser being.

But Scripture shows us that **correct language alone is not enough**. In Gospel of Mark 1:24, a demon says to Jesus: *“I know who you are—the Holy One of God!”*

This is a true statement, yet it comes from a spirit that is clearly not from God. That tells us something important: **it is possible to say true things about Jesus while still opposing Him**.

So, biblical discernment goes deeper than words. It asks whether Jesus is being presented in a way that is faithful to His full identity and authority.

Let’s make this more concrete by examining how the New Testament itself frames this test.

In Epistle to the Romans 10:9, Paul writes: *“If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord... you will be saved.”*

Here, the key term is **“Lord.”** To call Jesus “Lord” means recognizing His **authority, rule, and right to command obedience**. So discernment must ask: *Is Jesus presented as Lord, or only as a helper or rescuer without authority?*

In First Epistle to the Corinthians 1:18, Paul says: *“The message of the cross is... the power of God.”*

The **cross** refers to Jesus’ death for sin. It is central to the gospel. Any teaching that avoids, minimizes, or replaces the cross is no longer presenting the biblical Christ. So we must ask: *Is the cross central, or is it being pushed aside?*

In Gospel of Luke 6:46, Jesus Himself says: *“Why do you call me ‘Lord, Lord,’ and not do what I tell you?”*

Here, Jesus connects confession with **obedience**. **True acknowledgment of Christ leads to a life that follows Him**. So discernment must also ask: *Is obedience to Jesus required, or treated as optional?*

When we bring these passages together, we can define Christological discernment more clearly:

It is the practice of evaluating every teaching, spirit, or experience by asking whether it presents Jesus as He truly is: **Lord, crucified Savior, and rightful authority over life.**

Any influence that: *reduces His authority, removes the centrality of His cross, or ignores the call to obey Him is not aligned with the Spirit of God, no matter how spiritual it may appear.*

The Role of the Holy Spirit in Discernment

While discernment requires careful thinking, the New Testament makes it clear that it is not something we can achieve by human ability alone. **It depends on the work of the Holy Spirit.**

In First Epistle to the Corinthians 2:14, Paul writes: *“The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God... and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned.”*

The term **“natural person”** refers to someone operating only with ordinary human understanding, apart from the Spirit. Paul’s point is that spiritual truth cannot be fully grasped by human reasoning alone. **It requires spiritual perception, which comes from the Holy Spirit.**

Earlier in the same passage, in First Epistle to the Corinthians 2:10, Paul says: *“The Spirit searches all things, even the deep things of God.”*

This tells us that the Holy Spirit has **complete knowledge of God’s truth**. He is not limited or partial in understanding. Therefore, He is fully able to guide believers into what is true and expose what is false.

However, and this is very important: the Spirit does not work independently of what God has already revealed in Scripture.

Jesus makes this clear in Gospel of John 14:26: *“The Helper, the Holy Spirit... will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you.”*

Notice the connection: the Spirit **reminds** and **teaches** what Jesus has already spoken. This means the Spirit’s role is not to introduce completely new and unrelated teachings, but to **illuminate, clarify, and apply the truth already given in Christ.**

From this, we can define the Spirit’s role in discernment: **The Holy Spirit enables believers to understand, recognize, and apply God’s truth, especially as revealed in Jesus Christ and recorded in Scripture.**

This also gives us an important safeguard. If someone claims spiritual insight or discernment that **contradicts Scripture**, it cannot come from the Holy Spirit. The Spirit of God does not oppose the Word of God.

*So, true discernment always holds two things together: **Dependence on the Holy Spirit** for understanding; **Submission to Scripture** as the final authority*

When these are separated, error quickly follows. But when they remain together, believers are equipped to discern rightly.

The Gift of Discerning of Spirits

When Paul discusses spiritual gifts in the church, he includes something very specific in First Epistle to the Corinthians 12:10: “...to another the working of miracles, to another prophecy, to another the discernment of spirits...”

To understand this exegetically, we need to pay attention to both the wording and the context. Paul is listing **spiritual gifts**: that is, abilities given by the Holy Spirit to believers for the benefit of the church (1 Corinthians 12:7). These are not natural talents but **Spirit-enabled functions**.

The phrase “discernment of spirits” (Greek: *diakrisis pneumatōn*) refers to the ability to **distinguish between different spiritual sources**. The word *pneumatōn* (“spirits”) is plural, which already tells us that more than one type of spiritual influence is in view.

So this gift is not simply about reading people’s emotions or judging behavior on the surface. It is about recognizing **what lies behind** a spiritual expression: its true origin.

We can see why this is necessary when we connect it with First Epistle of John 4:1: “...test the spirits to see whether they are from God...”

What John commands for all believers in a general sense, Paul describes here as a **specific gifting** given to some believers in a more immediate or sharpened way.

From the broader teaching of Scripture, we can identify at least three possible sources this gift helps to distinguish:

The Spirit of God - the Holy Spirit, who produces truth and holiness (Galatians 5:22–23)

The human spirit - what arises from a person’s own inner thoughts or emotions (Proverbs 20:5)

Demonic spirits - deceptive spiritual beings opposed to God (1 Timothy 4:1)

The purpose of this gift becomes clearer when we consider Paul’s concern for the church. In 1 Corinthians 12–14, he repeatedly emphasizes **order, edification, and truth** in the gathered community. This means the gift of discernment serves to **protect the church from deception and confusion**, ensuring that what is accepted as spiritual is truly from God.

It is also important to define what this gift does *not* do. It is not primarily about guessing people’s hidden motives. Scripture warns against judging motives prematurely (1 Corinthians 4:5). Instead, this gift focuses on **spiritual source**, not personal suspicion.

Because of this, the gift must be exercised with:

Humility - recognizing that the discerner is not infallible

Submission to Scripture - since all discernment must agree with God's Word

In simple terms, the gift of discerning of spirits is a Spirit-given ability to **recognize the true origin of spiritual activity**, for the safety and health of the church.

Discernment Between Flesh and Spirit

One of the most practical and often overlooked areas of discernment is learning to tell the difference between the **Holy Spirit's leading** and the impulses of the **flesh**.

To define our terms again:

The **Holy Spirit** leads in ways that align with God's truth and produce godly character (Galatians 5:22–23).

The **flesh** refers to the fallen human nature, which resists God even when it appears strong or sincere.

The tension between these two is clearly described in Epistle to the Romans 8:7: *"The mind governed by the flesh is hostile to God; it does not submit to God's law..."*

Notice that the flesh is not neutral: it is **opposed to God**. This is important because the flesh can still appear: passionate; sincere; even religious.

Yet, at its core, it resists submission to God.

A clear example of this appears in Gospel of Matthew 16:22–23. Peter takes Jesus aside and rebukes Him for speaking about His coming suffering and death: *"Never, Lord! This shall never happen to you!"*

On the surface, Peter's words sound caring and protective. He does not want Jesus to suffer. But Jesus responds: *"Get behind me, Satan... you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man."*

This moment is crucial for understanding discernment. Peter's response was: emotionally sincere; relationally motivated; seemingly reasonable.

Yet Jesus identifies it as **opposed to God's redemptive plan**. In fact, He traces it back to satanic influence because it resists the cross.

This shows us something very practical: **not every strong or sincere impulse is from God**.

From passages like this, we can begin to recognize patterns where discernment is needed:

When **emotion replaces obedience** - feelings become the guide instead of God's Word

When **zeal outruns submission** - strong enthusiasm moves ahead without alignment to God's will (Romans 10:2)

When **desire overrides God's timing** - we push for what we want instead of waiting on God

Biblical discernment, then, involves learning to pause and ask:

Does this align with God's revealed will?

Does this reflect the character of Christ?

Does this lead to obedience or self-direction?

In simple terms, discernment between flesh and Spirit is the ability to recognize that **intensity does not equal truth**, and that what feels right is not always what *is* right.

As believers grow, they learn not to trust every impulse, but to weigh it carefully in light of Scripture and the work of the Holy Spirit.

Discernment and Doctrine

Biblical discernment cannot be separated from sound teaching. In fact, Scripture shows that **false doctrine rarely appears as obvious rejection of truth**. More often, it comes quietly through convincing language, partial truths, or misplaced emphasis.

Paul warns the church in Epistle to the Colossians 2:4: *"I say this so that no one may deceive you with persuasive words."*

The phrase *"persuasive words"* points to communication that is **skillful and convincing**, but not necessarily true. This means error can sound reasonable, even spiritual, while still leading people away from Christ.

He gives a similar warning in Second Epistle to Timothy 4:3–4, where he says that a time will come when people will not endure sound teaching, but will gather teachers who suit their own desires. Here we see an important principle: **false teaching often grows where people prefer comfort over truth**.

To understand this, we need to define **doctrine** clearly. Doctrine simply means **the teaching of Scripture about God, salvation, and Christian living**. In Acts 20:27, Paul says:

"For I did not shrink from declaring to you the whole counsel of God."

The phrase *"whole counsel"* is important. It means the **full teaching of Scripture, not selective parts of it**. Discernment, therefore, requires familiarity with the whole Bible, not just favorite passages.

A key insight from Scripture is that error often begins not with outright denial of truth, but with **imbalanced truth**: when one aspect of doctrine is overstated while others

are ignored. For example, emphasizing God's love while ignoring His holiness, or emphasizing faith while neglecting obedience.

This is why doctrine and discernment work together. **Doctrine provides the standard; discernment applies it in real situations.** Without doctrine, discernment has no foundation.

Discernment Through Fruit and Pattern

Jesus gives one of the clearest practical tests for discernment in Gospel of Matthew 7:15–20: *“You will recognize them by their fruits... Every healthy tree bears good fruit, but the diseased tree bears bad fruit.”*

To understand this properly, we need to define what *“fruit”* means in biblical language. Fruit refers to the **visible outcomes of a person's life and ministry over time**: their character, behavior, and spiritual influence.

Jesus is teaching that true spiritual reality is not measured only by words or appearances, but by **consistent patterns**.

So what counts as *“good fruit”* in Scripture?

The New Testament repeatedly describes it as: humility (Philippians 2:3); obedience to God (John 14:15); teachability (James 1:21); holiness of life (1 Peter 1:15–16); love for truth (2 Thessalonians 2:10); endurance in faith (Hebrews 12:1)

These are not isolated moments, but **ongoing patterns shaped by the Spirit** (Galatians 5:22–23).

On the other hand, Jesus also warns that outward success or spiritual appearance can be misleading. That is why He says in Matthew 7 that some will do impressive works in His name, yet still be unknown to Him. This shows that **charisma, gifts, or visible success are not reliable indicators of spiritual truth**.

Over time, fruit reveals what is truly inside a person or ministry more clearly than their words ever can.

Discernment in the Life of the Church

The New Testament never treats discernment as a purely private activity. Instead, it is meant to function within the **community of believers**.

In First Epistle to the Corinthians 14:29, Paul gives a clear instruction: *“Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh what is said.”*

The word *“weigh”* means to **evaluate carefully and judge what is genuine**. This shows that prophetic speech itself was not accepted automatically, but was subject to communal evaluation.

This teaches an important theological principle: **God protects His church through shared discernment, not isolated judgment.** The body of Christ is designed to function with **plurality and accountability**, meaning believers help one another see clearly.

This is why private discernment, when detached from the church, becomes dangerous. Without correction and community, it can easily turn into:

suspicion of others; spiritual pride; or unchecked personal interpretations

But when discernment operates within the body of Christ, it produces the opposite effect. It strengthens unity, preserves truth, and builds maturity.

In simple terms, true biblical discernment does not divide the church, it **guards and grows it.**

The Danger of False Discernment

Scripture not only calls believers to develop discernment; it also warns that discernment itself can become distorted when it is not shaped by truth and love. In other words, it is possible to be “*discerning*” in a way that is actually unhealthy or unbiblical.

Paul describes one form of this danger in Second Epistle to Timothy 3:5, speaking of people who have “*a form of godliness but deny its power.*” The word “*form*” here refers to an **outward appearance of religion**: something that looks spiritual on the surface but lacks real transformation. The “*power*” refers to the **transforming work of God that produces true godliness** in a person’s life.

When discernment is disconnected from this transforming work of God, it often becomes distorted in several ways:

- It turns into **constant fault-finding**, where a person is always looking for what is wrong in others instead of what is true and good.
- It becomes **spiritual pride**, where someone feels superior because they believe they can “*see through*” everyone else.
- It can develop into **fear-based judgment**, where suspicion replaces trust and everything is seen as dangerous or false.
- It may even lead to an **obsession with error**, where attention is focused more on exposing falsehood than on knowing Christ.

The New Testament balances this tension clearly. **Truth without love becomes harsh judgment, while love without truth becomes compromise.** Paul captures this balance in Epistle to the Ephesians 4:15, where he speaks of “*speaking the truth in love.*” Both elements are necessary. Truth gives discernment its structure; love gives it its spirit.

So biblical discernment is not suspicion, and it is not softness. It is **truth held in a loving and humble heart**, shaped by Christ.

Discernment as End-Time Readiness

Jesus and the apostles consistently teach that deception will increase as history moves toward its climax. This means discernment is not only a present need: it is also part of **end-time readiness**.

In Gospel of Matthew 24:24, Jesus warns: *“False christs and false prophets will appear and perform great signs and wonders to deceive, if possible, even the elect.”*

The key idea here is not just false teaching, but **powerful deception**: signs and wonders that can look convincing even to sincere believers. This shows that miracles alone are not a safe guide for truth.

Paul gives a similar warning in Second Epistle to the Thessalonians 2:9–12, describing the activity of the *“lawless one”* who comes with *“all power and false signs and wonders.”* The phrase *“false signs”* does not mean they are fake in appearance, but that they are **deceptive in origin and purpose**: they lead people away from truth.

From these passages, we learn that end-time deception will not always look weak or obvious. In fact, it may appear:

- powerful
- convincing
- spiritually impressive

This is why faithfulness in the last days requires more than enthusiasm or religious excitement. **It requires a life grounded in:**

- **truth** (anchored in Scripture)
- **endurance** (steadfastness under pressure)
- **love for righteousness** (a deep desire for what is right before God)

Jesus does not describe the faithful church as the most impressive or the most vocal. Instead, He implies that true perseverance belongs to those who remain rooted in His word, even when deception becomes widespread.

In simple terms, the church that endures is not the one that is most emotionally driven or most visible: **it is the one that is most grounded in truth and steady in obedience.**

Conclusion

Discernment as Formed Spiritual Sight

When we bring all of this together, we can describe discernment of spirits as a kind of **spiritual sight**: the ability to perceive reality as God defines it in His Word.

EDC 112

It is not fear-driven suspicion, and it is not cynical distrust of everything. Instead, it is a calm and steady clarity shaped by Scripture and guided by the Holy Spirit.

Biblical discernment allows believers to:

- see clearly without being deceived
- remain sober without becoming cynical
- stay faithful without compromising truth

In this sense, the goal of this teaching is not simply to give information, but to form disciples who are spiritually stable and biblically grounded.

Signed:

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